The Political Disinformation Epidemic: How Algorithms and Cable News Drive U.S. Polarization

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Abstract. This paper asks how disinformation across different forms of media affects political polarization in the United States. It reviews twelve sources, including four peer-reviewed studies, one systematic review, and survey work from Pew Research Center and Brookings. Two mechanisms carry most of the effect. Social media algorithms rank content by engagement rather than accuracy, which is one reason false claims spread roughly six times faster than true ones on X, and which sorts users into filter bubbles that reinforce the claims they already hold. Cable news reaches the same end deliberately, through identity journalism that ties party to self-image; 64 percent of Americans now say democracy is in crisis, and the news sources the two parties trust barely overlap. The common thread is antidemocratic attitudes and partisan animosity, or AAPA: cross-partisan exposure backfires when the content carries high AAPA and reduces hostility when it does not. The paper recommends prebunking and K-12 digital literacy on the consumption side, and funding transparency for cable news plus algorithmic down-ranking of high-AAPA and bot-amplified content on the spread side. The evidence is correlational and drawn entirely from existing literature, so none of it establishes cause.

Keywords. disinformation; political polarization; social media algorithms; identity journalism; digital literacy

1. Introduction

Following the 2020 presidential election, false claims of election fraud spread rapidly online. The spread of disinformation culminated in the January 6, 2021 attack on the U.S. Capitol. Flavia Roscini, an international affairs researcher and masters candidate at Boston University, adds that this event served as a symbol of the volatile and dangerous political climate in the U.S. (Roscini, 2024). That claim is not proven only symbolically by the attack. Gabriel Sanchez, a political science professor at the University of New Mexico, and Keesha Middlemass, an American politics professor at Howard University, find that 64 percent of Americans think democracy in the U.S. is in crisis (Sanchez & Middlemass, 2022).

When distrust in government is pervasive and polarization is ubiquitous, it becomes imperative to examine how disinformation across different forms of media affects political polarization in the United States. That is the question this paper asks.

2. Scope and Sources

This paper is a literature review. It uses no original data collection and no original statistical analysis, so every number reported below is taken from a published source and attributed there.

Source base. Twelve sources, published between 2018 and 2025. Four are peer-reviewed empirical studies (Bail et al., 2018; Marks et al., 2019; Schwalbe et al., 2024; and the Science study reported by Lloyd, 2025). One is a systematic review of disinformation on social media (Surjatmodjo et al., 2024). Two are survey-based reports from research institutions, Pew Research Center and Brookings. The remainder are analytical pieces and news reporting used for definitions, framing, and recent examples.

Selection. Sources were chosen to cover both delivery channels under study, social media and cable news, and to include at least one source that cuts against the paper's own argument. Bail et al. (2018) serves that role: it reports that cross-partisan exposure can fail or backfire.

3. Literature Review

3.1 What disinformation is

Disinformation is "information deliberately created and disseminated to mislead or deceive" (Surjatmodjo et al., 2024, p. 1). Domestically, politicians use disinformation to demonize opponents and hold their own support, which creates an us-versus-them mentality that furthers political polarization (Roscini, 2024). Internationally, foreign adversaries use disinformation as a weapon. Following Charlie Kirk's assassination, Russia, Iran, and China spread disinformation online to make the U.S. appear more politically fractured than it is (Klepper, 2025).

3.2 Social media algorithms

Social media algorithms play a key role in the spread of disinformation. Disinformation spreads six times faster than truth on Twitter, now X (Surjatmodjo et al., 2024, p. 1). Surjatmodjo, of the faculty of social and political sciences at Hasanuddin University, and colleagues explain that this is because social media algorithms prioritize engagement over veracity. Disinformation garners engagement because it usually presents new facts, is emotionally appealing, and often uses bots to repost and spread the content (Surjatmodjo et al., 2024, pp. 1, 5, 10).

De-Wit, an assistant professor of political psychology at the University of Cambridge, and colleagues explain that a system which prioritizes engagement puts users into "filter bubbles," where algorithms surround users with the ideological content they already prefer and keep them from encountering other perspectives (de-Wit et al., 2019). Taken together, these sources show that the rapid spread of disinformation and the formation of filter bubbles fuel political polarization, because false and polarizing ideas are reinforced while competing views are excluded.

The effect reaches beyond politics. In a peer-reviewed study published in Cognition, Marks, an experimental psychology researcher, and colleagues found that when people performed a completely non-political task and needed help, they often asked the person who aligned with them politically, even when that person was not the most qualified to advise them (Marks et al., 2019, p. 75). Filter bubbles do not only separate Americans by perspective. The resulting polarization makes them distrust and avoid the other side regardless of context.

A logical solution would be exposing people to other opinions. In a peer-reviewed study published in PNAS, the sociology professor Bail and colleagues had users interact with posts from the opposing political side on X and found that this either had no effect on partisan attitudes or strengthened them (Bail et al., 2018, p. 9216). Lloyd, a science writer at Northeastern reporting on a peer-reviewed study published in Science, notes a different result: when content lacked "antidemocratic attitudes and partisan animosity" (Lloyd, 2025), or AAPA, people's opinion of the other political party improved. Algorithms highlight content with high levels of AAPA because it draws the strongest emotional reactions (Surjatmodjo et al., 2024). The two findings are compatible. The problem is not contact with opposing political content. It is how polarizing that content is.

3.3 Cable news and identity journalism

Where social media pushes polarizing content indirectly, through ranking, cable news networks do it deliberately, as a business model. Roscini clarifies that in order to maximize ratings and engagement, cable news shifted toward "identity journalism," making polarizing statements that split opposing parties along the differences between them. This creates a "tribal mentality" that leads to irrational support of one's own group and to increased engagement (Roscini, 2024).

Shearer, a senior researcher at Pew Research Center, and colleagues show very large discrepancies between the media outlets and news sources that Democrats and Republicans trust (Shearer et al., 2025). Identity journalism explains why those gaps exist: when people attach a political party to their identity, it becomes harder to question the party or the news sources associated with it. Cable news disinformation therefore affects polarization in a distinct way. It turns political disagreement into a threat against the self.

4. Discussion

Both mechanisms converge on the same content. Social media algorithms favor high-AAPA material because it generates emotional engagement; cable news favors it because it builds tribal loyalty. The result is a media landscape in which the most polarizing disinformation receives the most screen time, through two independent routes and for two different reasons.

That convergence also locates the leverage point. If the problem were exposure to opposing views, the Bail et al. (2018) result would close the question, because exposure there did nothing or made matters worse. The Science finding reported by Lloyd (2025) shows that the same exposure reduces hostility once AAPA is stripped out. AAPA, not partisanship itself, is the variable that moves. That is what any intervention has to target.

Two caveats belong here rather than in the recommendations. First, the sources disagree in ways that are not fully resolved; Bail et al. and the Science study were run on different platforms, with different content, at different times, and the comparison between them is interpretive rather than experimental. Second, every finding reported above is correlational or experimental at small scale, and none of it establishes that media disinformation causes the national-level polarization that survey data record.

5. Recommendations

Political disinformation spreads through both cable news and social media. The recommendations below address two sides of the issue, consumption and spread, while avoiding infringements on free speech (Cook & Lewandowsky, 2023).

5.1 Consumption

School districts and state education agencies should fund digital literacy instruction in K-12, and should build it around prebunking rather than fact-checking alone. Surjatmodjo et al. (2024) find a "negative correlation between digital literacy levels and vulnerability to disinformation" (p. 6), and Sanchez and Middlemass (2022) recommend digital literacy courses for K-12 students on that basis.

The approach has to be designed with care. Simply teaching people to fact-check information online will not work, because when information connects to a person's political identity they are more likely to accept it even when it is false (Schwalbe et al., 2024). Prebunking, which warns people about the manipulation techniques used in disinformation before they encounter them, counteracts this. It is effective over the long term, but digital literacy education may not reach people who are already highly polarized and settled inside extremist filter bubbles (Sanchez & Middlemass, 2022). Even an informed person can weigh emotion over analysis and act on disinformation anyway.

5.2 Spread

Legislators and platform operators should act on the supply side. Because the cable news contribution is deliberate, policy aimed at it should start with funding transparency, which, combined with digital literacy, would help create an environment where factual reporting draws the most attention and the commercial incentive shifts with it.

For social media, policy should focus on having platforms mark and down-rank content that is both false and high in AAPA, rather than restricting cross-partisan exposure, which the evidence does not support as a target. Platforms can also work to slow the effect bots have on spreading disinformation (Surjatmodjo et al., 2024). Both measures carry real costs: free speech objections and implementation expense, neither of which this paper resolves.

6. Limitations

No causal claims. This paper is a review of existing literature. It cannot establish that disinformation causes political polarization, only that the two are associated in the sources reviewed, and that experimental work finds effects in that direction at small scale.
No original data. Every figure reported here comes from a published source. Nothing was collected, coded, or recalculated by the author, and no number should be attributed to this paper.
Source count and mix. Twelve sources, of which four are peer-reviewed empirical studies. Two findings reach this paper through journalism reporting on a study rather than through the study itself, which adds a layer between the claim and the evidence.
Scope. The analysis is limited to the United States and to two delivery channels, social media and cable news. Radio, podcasts, messaging apps, and local news are not examined, and the findings should not be extended to other countries.
Shifting platforms. The platform evidence spans 2018 to 2025, a period in which X changed ownership, moderation policy, and ranking. Findings from early in that window may not describe the platform as it now operates.
Unresolved conflict in the evidence. Bail et al. (2018) and the study reported by Lloyd (2025) reach opposing conclusions about cross-partisan exposure. This paper reconciles them through AAPA, but that reconciliation is an interpretation, not a tested result.

7. Conclusion

The January 6, 2021 attack on the U.S. Capitol stands as a symbol of an increasingly polarized political environment in the United States. The research reviewed here suggests that limiting malicious bots, down-ranking the amplified spread of high-AAPA content on social media, and implementing prebunking campaigns and digital literacy classes would reduce disinformation and its effect on political polarization.

A stronger follow-up study would need what this one lacks: longitudinal panel data tracking the same individuals' media diets and partisan attitudes over several years, with AAPA coded at the content level, so that the direction of the relationship could be tested rather than inferred. Unless disinformation is addressed, Americans will continue to be misinformed, and the decisions they make about their leaders will be made on that basis.

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CONTRIBUTIONS

H. Mahmood is the sole author. He selected the sources, wrote the manuscript, and verified the citations.